Study: Younger Kids Feel More Excited About AI Stories

From: IndieWire Mined: 2026-10-22 5 min read

How do young people feel when they watch videos or stories made with **artificial intelligence**, or AI? A new study says it depends a lot on their age.

The study comes from UCLA and the Center for Scholars and Storytellers. It **surveyed** young people between the ages of 10 and 24 about movies, shows and storytelling.

Overall, 53.8 percent of them said AI content made them feel "**fascinated**" or "excited." Only 32.1 percent said they felt "doomed" or "scared."

But the feelings changed as the age groups got older. When asked to finish the sentence "Watching a story with AI in it makes me feel...," just 9.7 percent of 10- to 13-year-olds chose "doom." That rose to 25.1 percent for 14- to 18-year-olds and 27.4 percent for 18- to 24-year-olds. Nearly half of the 10- to 13-year-olds said they felt excitement.

The study says many of these feelings come from AI videos that young people see on social media, such as silly clips of talking fruit. It suggests there may be a **generation gap** between Gen Z and the younger Generation Alpha, who may view AI more positively.

One 13-year-old in the study said they wanted AI shown "in a balanced and realistic way," with both its benefits and risks, including AI helping people learn and solve problems.

The study, now in its fifth year, also looked at other topics. More than half of young people said seeing a movie in a theater would be their top weekend activity with friends. Many also preferred hopeful messages on screen, and most did not want social media **influencers** in their movies and shows.

Word Treasure

artificial intelligence -- Artificial intelligence is computer technology that can do tasks that usually need human thinking, like writing or making pictures.

surveyed -- Surveyed means asked a group of people questions to learn what they think.

generation gap -- A generation gap is a difference in views or habits between people of different ages.

influencers -- Influencers are people who have many followers on social media and can affect what others like or buy.

fascinated -- Fascinated means extremely interested in something.

Background you need

Artificial intelligence tools can now create videos, pictures and stories, and many of these clips spread on social media.

Researchers survey young people to learn how they feel about new technology and the shows and movies they watch.

People are often grouped into generations by when they were born, such as Gen Z and the younger Generation Alpha.

Comparing answers by age helps researchers see whether feelings about something like AI change as people grow older.

Break it down

LEAD: How young people feel about AI stories depends a lot on age
WHO: UCLA and the Center for Scholars and Storytellers surveyed people ages 10 to 24
KEY FINDING: 53.8 percent felt fascinated or excited; 32.1 percent felt doomed or scared
  +- AGE PATTERN: doom chosen by 9.7 percent of 10-13s, 25.1 percent of 14-18s, 27.4 percent of 18-24s
  +- YOUNGEST: nearly half of 10-13s felt excitement
SOURCE OF FEELINGS: AI videos on social media, such as talking fruit clips
VOICE: A 13-year-old wants AI shown in a balanced, realistic way
OTHER FINDINGS: Movie theaters top weekend pick; hopeful messages preferred; most do not want influencers in movies

Why it matters

As AI-made videos become common, knowing how different ages feel about them can shape how stories, shows and lessons about AI are made for young people.

Test what you remember

1. Which groups ran the study?

- (A) Harvard and Netflix
- (B) TikTok and YouTube
- (C) UCLA and the Center for Scholars and Storytellers
- (D) NASA and Google

2. What ages did the study include?

- (A) 30 to 50
- (B) 18 to 40
- (C) 5 to 12
- (D) 10 to 24

3. What percent said AI content made them feel fascinated or excited?

- (A) 9.7 percent
- (B) 53.8 percent
- (C) 75 percent
- (D) 32.1 percent

4. Which age group was least likely to choose "doom"?

- (A) All groups were the same
- (B) 10- to 13-year-olds
- (C) 14- to 18-year-olds
- (D) 18- to 24-year-olds

5. Where do many of these feelings about AI come from?

- (A) Newspapers
- (B) Radio shows
- (C) School lessons
- (D) AI videos on social media

6. What did more than half of young people pick as their top weekend activity with friends?

- (A) Going to the beach
- (B) Seeing a movie in a theater
- (C) Watching influencers
- (D) Playing video games

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: B 4: B 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. A 13-year-old in the study: Wants AI shown in a balanced and realistic way, with both its benefits and risks.

2. The study: Suggests there may be a generation gap, with Generation Alpha viewing AI more positively than Gen Z.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):